



Age no bar for e-literacy!

office, KSEB office, etc. are close by, most of the villagers visit my e-Kendra for e-payment!”

There are certain criteria to be met for starting an e-Kendra. An entrepreneur should himself be a minimally qualified IT person, meaning he should have had basic exposure to computers and IT. Every e-Kendra would have sole proprietorship with a minimum of three qualified trainers.

An Akshaya e-Kendra requires an investment of about Rs 3 lakh, and should have a minimum area of 400 square feet. Purchase of hardware and software should be according to Government guidelines. The three-tier Panchayat (Gram, Block and District) pays the entrepreneurs Rs 100 per person made computer literate at their e-Kendras.

Before opening an e-Kendra, an entrepreneur must go through a screening process for assessing their capacity to run and manage one. In addition, those wanting to be trainers have to attend special training workshops. The district's Akshaya Project Cell also has well-qualified staff for monitoring and evaluation of the activities at the Kendras.

Siddique, a businessman from Perinthalmanna, initiated several businesses right in his Akshaya e-Kendra—a hotel, an STD/ISD centre, a bookshop, computer and mobile phone sales and services, and more. He says, “The Akshaya e-Kendra is a service agency to the people in my village; I am least bothered about the profit from my businesses and e-Kendra! Four to six people visit my e-Kendra daily to register their passport online under the recently-started online passport registration programme.”

The E-Literacy Course

An e-literacy course is 15 hours long, with a 90-minute session per day, for which one pays Rs 40. Of the household, women and aged male citizens are given priority. Qualified trainers (with a minimum of a Post Graduate Diploma in Computer Applications) provide training along with interactive CD-based content designed in the local language by the Centre for Development of Imaging Technology (C-DIT), Kerala.

The content of the CD is user-friendly, with commentary in Malayalam and interactive content and games. After the 15-hour instruction period is completed, one must take an online test.

After attaining e-literacy, the individual would be able to use word processing, gaming, and entertainment programs, and use the Internet for e-mail, browsing, chatting, and so on. Those who have achieved basic e-literacy could enrol in advanced programmes such as e-Vidya—Microsoft Office Package, Internet for all, Arabic typing tutor, Microsoft Unlimited Potential Programme, and more. Upon completion of these programmes, the individual is awarded a Government-recognised certificate from Kerala State IT Mission and the Computer Society of India.

Available for school-going students are computer-aided learning programmes such as Vijayabheri, Intel Learn Programme, Computer Assisted Learning by the Azim Premji Foundation, and various others, along with e-tuition facilities. Also, some trainers at the e-Kendras help them with their school projects.

100 per cent e-literate means *everyone*!

Malappuram On Top

Since Malappuram is the pilot district, the people enjoy many benefits over those of other districts. Kunchi Bava, who is physically challenged, is well known amongst the residents of Chapapalli village, for his multi-service Akshaya e-Kendra. He says with pride, “Thus far, around 500 families in this village have achieved computer literacy through this e-Kendra.” As of now, 400 Akshaya e-Kendras are functioning successfully.

Of 6.5 lakh people, 5.9 lakh individuals have achieved e-literacy through the project, of which 25,738 are certified. Of the e-literates in Malappuram, more than 65 per cent are women. The majority of the trainers at the e-Kendras are women, and there are certain e-Kendras run solely by female entrepreneurs. UNESCO has recently shown interest in supporting the Akshaya project in the field of women empowerment.

Many women, after gaining computer literacy via the project, go on to run e-Kendras. Online education services help students not only via e-tuitions, but also by way of counselling for their career options.

The project has also generated direct employment for 7,400 people—including the staff at the e-Kendras, content developers, and the project staff.

Future Plans

A future Akshaya e-Kendra would be a multi-purpose centre providing information, communication, and business opportunities, using the available IT infrastructure. The Kerala State IT Mission plans to roll out several new programmes at the Akshaya e-Kendras. After citizens, 38,000 government employees will receive computer training at the centres.

The next step would be sector-wise intervention, such as the starting of clubs such as the Akshaya student club in various schools, and Bhoomi, a farmers' club, in all Panchayats.

Malappuram is looked up to as an example, and the project will be rolled out in six more districts of the 14 districts in Kerala. Small steps, but inspirational. Is achieving 100 per cent literacy in the country impossible? We don't think so. ■

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